Porunan) at Talayalanganam. He is also given credit for capturing Milalai and Mutthuru (Pudukottai district) two important places from a Vel chief. He is praised as the lord of Korkai, and as the overlord of the southern Paratavar, a martial and fishing community of the Tirunelveli coast.

5.4 Social Formation in Tamil Eco-zones

Sangam poems help us understand the social formation of the time. According to the *thinai* concept, Tamilagam was divided into five landscapes or eco-regions, Ainthinai namely *Kurinji*, *Mullai*, *Marutam*, *Neythal* and *Palai*. Each region had distinct characteristics – a presiding deity, people and cultural life according to the environmental conditions, as follows:

DDIK8T

Kurinji	hilly region: hunting and gathering
Mullai	forested region: pastoralism combined with shifting cultivation
Marutham	riverine tract: agriculture using plough and irrigation.
Neythal	coastal land: fishing and salt making.
Palai	parched land: Unsuitable for cultivation and hence people took to cattle lifting and robbery.

5.5 Tamil Polity

In a way this *thinai* classification is said to reflect the uneven socio-economic developments of the different localities. That is seen in the political forms too. Three levels of rulers are found:1) Kizhar, 2) Velir, 3) Vendar. *Kizhar* were the heads of the villages or a small territory, later known as *nadu*. They were the chiefs of tribal communities living in specific areas. The Vendar were kings controlling larger, fertile territories.

The Velir, who were many in number, controlled the territories of varied geographical nature, mainly hilly and forest areas, that were in between the muvendar's fertile territories. Chiefs like Athiyaman, Pari, Ay, Evvi and Irungo each commanded a big area, rich in natural resources. They were generous patrons of the poets and bards. They had military power and there were frequent wars among these chiefs on account of capture of cattle. On many occasions they seem to have united and confronted one or other of the three kings.

There are differing views among scholars, with regard to the political organization of the three kingdoms. The earlier and dominant view is that the Sangam Age society was a well-organised state society. The other view which is put forward in recent decades is that the polities of the Cheras, Cholas and Pandyas were pre-state chiefdoms. The arguments for the latter view are:

1. No social stratification is noticed.
2. Proper territorial association is absent.
3. Destructive warfare did not allow the development of agriculture and surplus production for the emergence of the state.
4. No evidence of taxation as in the governments of North India.

The following counter arguments are presented in response:

- A closer look at the Sangam literature reveals that social differentiation is evident in the Marutham region.
- The territorial associations are very clear in the case of the Muvendar, and their important position is corroborated by the Greco-Roman texts from the first century CE.
- Warfare for territorial expansion was a major theme of *Puratthinai*
- Evidence for taxation at the highways and in the port of Kaviripattinam is cited. The Chera king is spoken as receiving the resources from the hills and the port of Musiri.

XI History - Lesson 5.indd 70 05-03-2020 17:03:25